Who makes music software accessible?

The Qualities of Convivial Tools and Their Relevance to Music Software Accessibility

Alex Lucas · James Cunningham · Jacob Harrison · Franziska Schroeder · Andrew McPherson

Queen's University Belfast · Imperial College London · ACM TACCESS 18(3), 2025

Designers can’t see the future

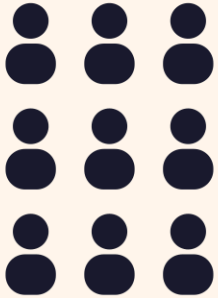
- Usability tests: a handful of people, for about an hour
- But tools live in a busy world of people, places and things

> "It isn’t only that we use tools; we think with them." — Alva Noë

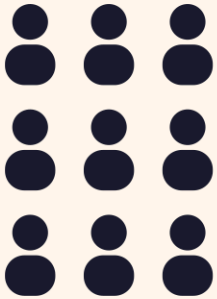
We can't fully anticipate how a tool will be used until it's in use.

We talked with 20 sound creatives

9
Advanced



9
Intermediate



2
Beginner



All blind or visually impaired · 9 countries · 2-hour interviews and demos

Three gaps



> "There is a lot of goodwill without the backup." — Peter Bosher

Communities build the bridges

1. **Mailing lists and WhatsApp groups** for each DAW (digital audio workstation)
2. **OSARA**: community-built screen-reader access for the Reaper DAW
3. **Thousands of preset files**, made by hand, so a synth can be browsed by ear

> "The WhatsApp groups are very voice message focused." — Rory McDonald

A DAW is often accessible only with the community's knowledge.

Sighted users get a working product at the point of purchase.

Ivan Illich: *Tools for Conviviality* (1973)

A convivial tool is:

1. Easy to learn by using it
2. Used when and where **you** choose
3. Adaptable to **you**

...and community is at its heart.

Three design guidelines

1

Build accessible ecosystems

Tutorials and manuals without visual cues

2

Embrace interdependent access

Credit community work, and point people to it

3

Design for designers

Open extension points: the DAW is ajar

Make tools malleable, and support the communities who change them.

"Nothing about us without us", where **us** is a community.

Thank you!

Feedback

Feedback, 2 minutes:
noiseguaranteed.org/assets26/feedback

Slides and script:
noiseguaranteed.org/assets26

a.lucas@qub.ac.uk

Slides + script